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Session 6 — Dashboard, Styling, and User Experience

Objective

Improve the application's visual design and usability. Build a meaningful dashboard that gives the student a useful overview of their modules.

1. Why Good Interface Design Matters

A functional application needs to be readable and easy to use. This week you focus on HTML5 structure and CSS3 styling to make the application feel polished and professional. Good design does not mean complex — it means clear, consistent, and readable.

2. Dashboard Ideas

Your dashboard.php should give the student useful information at a glance:

- Total number of modules registered
- The module with the nearest exam date
- The module with the highest difficulty
- Average progress across all modules
- A direct button to Add a new module or Generate the AI plan

3. CSS3 Styling Tips

Technology	What It Does
Flexbox / Grid	Use to align cards and columns without complex code
Color consistency	Choose 2-3 colors and use them throughout — avoid too many colors
Font size	Use 16px+ for body text to keep readability high
Spacing	Add padding and margin to every block — never let elements touch the edges
Responsive basics	Test on a narrower window to see if the layout breaks

4. Practical Tasks This Week

1	Redesign dashboard.php with a clean layout using CSS Flexbox or Grid
2	Show a summary: total modules, nearest exam, most difficult module
3	Style the modules table or card list with colors and clear spacing
4	Add a navigation bar (nav) with links to Dashboard, Add Module, and Logout

- 5 Style all forms consistently: input fields, labels, and buttons
- 6 Optional: add a search bar or a filter by difficulty or exam date
- 7 Test the layout at different window sizes

Expected Result by End of Week

- ✓ The application looks cleaner and more professional
- ✓ The dashboard displays useful summary information
- ✓ Navigation between pages is easy and consistent
- ✓ Forms and tables are styled and readable

Advice & Common Mistakes to Avoid

- ! Do not overcomplicate the design — clarity is more important than decoration
- ! Use an external CSS file (style.css) and link it on every page with <link>
- ! Avoid inline styles — keep CSS in one place for easy maintenance
- ! Simple HTML cards with colored borders look professional and are easy to build
- ! Good design is simple design

Prepare for Next Week

- Prepare your module data — make sure all fields are correctly filled in the database
- Review how APIs work: what is an API key, what is a JSON request and response
- Read the documentation of at least one AI API (GitHub Models, Hugging Face, or OpenRouter)